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Mike Wofford

Pianist Mike Wofford was born on February 25, 1938 in San Antonio, Texas. During his career in jazz he has played alongside an impressive list of jazz notables, including Chet Baker, Lee Konitz, Sweets Edison and Benny Golson. Mike has toured with Benny Carter and accompanied vocalists Sarah Vaughan and Ella Fitzgerald. He was an integral part of Ella's "All That Jazz" CD, which earned a Grammy nomination in 1991. His wide ranging piano style has been recorded frequently, and can be heard in a solo setting on "Mike Wofford, Live at Maybeck" on Concord Records.

Mike was interviewed in San Diego, California on February 13, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in San Diego, California. I'm pleased to have as my guest jazz pianist Mike Wofford.

MW: Pleased to be here.

MR: It's nice to be in San Diego coming from the winter of the northeast.

MW: It's a little wetter here this year than typically, but it's still nice.

MR: We're not going to go home with a tan this time.

MW: No, not this time I'm afraid.

MR: What's San Diego's music atmosphere like down here? Can you play here a lot or do you have to travel elsewhere?

MW: Well I think it's like most cities its size across the country. The jazz scene is perilous at best and from one year to the next it'll be better than others. Right now it's not great. We've lost a couple of what were the major clubs here. There is always activity and there are wonderful players here, great players working, but I wouldn't call it a thriving jazz scene right now. But again, I think that's true in most cities I've been in from one year to the next. This next year may be a complete turnaround. But right now it's not as good as it had been a couple of years ago. But it's a very vibrant town musically. There's a lot of interesting stuff going on, a lot of interesting music experimentation and some wonderful, wonderful players and a lot of really wonderful young players. The UCSD Music Department here, the University of California in LaJolla, has a wonderful music department where jazz and experimental music are concerned. And also out at San Diego State University. So they help.

MR: Is there a stronger influence, being that you're so close to Mexico, in the Latin end of things?

MW: Well it's interesting. There is now, but that would not have been the case up until even just a few years ago. Typically I would say no, that would not have been the case years

ago here. I mean you would draw that conclusion, it seems like an obvious connection, but it's only been recently that that has really occurred. But now, yeah, it's very strong. There is more Latin-oriented music of one type of another, whether it's Brazilian or Afro-Cuban or whatever. And blues are generally active in the city right now than traditional jazz or acoustic jazz. There is, like everywhere, there is a certain amount of contemporary jazz or whatever term you want to use that sometimes is borderline jazz at best, and we have our share of that. Some of it's fine and some of it's not so fine, but anyway, if that answers your question.

MR: I like that term you just said, "borderline jazz." Maybe that should be the name in the record bins, instead of "new age" instead of "fusion," we'll call it "borderline jazz."

MW: Well you know I don't just categorically — a lot of people my age in my generation do just categorically rule out a lot of types of musical trends. I've tried to stay away from that over the years. I guess I have pretty eclectic tastes. I love a lot of different kinds of music and a lot of different genres, if it's honest, if it's real. And I think most of us know when it's real pretty quickly, and we know when it's not. And in the — whatever you want to call it — of course in the 70s, when it first started coming to the forefront, we called it "fusion" or "jazz-rock," you know those were kind of primitive early terms. And now I think in different parts of the country it even has different terms, whether it's "pop-jazz," "contemporary jazz," "light jazz," whatever. But I think there's good and bad. I've heard some people that are marvelous in that area. I love the Yellowjackets for instance. But a lot of it I call jazz for people who don't like jazz. And of course Joe Zawinul has done wonderful things over the years. So you can't just paint with a wide brush and rule out — but a lot of it is false advertising as far as I'm concerned.

MR: Trying to jump on some bandwagon perhaps? Although I don't know how big the wagon is.

MW: Well I don't know. I talked to people in that field and they complain about the same things others do as far as the work. It's not as if they're finding a whole lot of outlets either. I mean the club situation in the United States is not great for any kind of music. Worse than it's ever been I think, and there are certain sociological reasons for that, and economic considerations. But it's not great. I think jazz, you know the real thing, whatever that means to you, I think we all pretty much understand is if it's to survive it has to find other venues. It's not — the night club is a thing of the past I think for the most part. There will always be a certain amount going in major areas like New York and Los Angeles, and to a certain extent San Francisco, although San Francisco has the same problems we do here I think.

MR: Do you think putting jazz in the concert hall has been a good thing for the music?

MW: That's a great question. Here again, I disagree with a lot of my peers and think that it's the ideal environment, the concert hall I mean. People are quiet, no cash register noise, no peripheral distractions. But those are the very things that I grew up with, and to me some of the best music happens in those very environments, in clubs where it may be noisy, people talking and laughing, and noise going on behind the bar and sometimes the most creative moments happen in those environs. And a concert hall can be deadly, you know? Not always, but I mean it can be. We've all experienced that. So ideally I'd love to see it all coexist. I'd love to see a healthy night club scene and concert outlets for — at least for a certain amount of activity, but I think it's going to have to be more and more concerts and the universities help there a lot I think, and it's certainly not happening on T.V., we know that, and anyway, yeah. But I have real mixed emotions. I don't always think those absolutely quiet, attentive situations are the most conducive to great jazz playing sometimes.

MR: There's not as much interaction between the audience so it's hard for the musicians to get feedback, or energy from an audience. It's kind of out there beyond the footlights I think.

MW: I think so. Not everyone agrees, but I think yeah, I would agree with what you're saying.

MR: Well you said the night club scene is what you were familiar with when you were growing up. And you were born in San Antonio, is that right? Did you stay there a long time?

MW: No. We really lived in Dallas, my family. But we happened to — my father did a lot of traveling in his work and we were in San Antonio at that particular time for a brief time, I think just a few months. But really Dallas was where we lived. But then when I was about six, five or six we came out here to San Diego, which was during the war, in the Second World War at that time. And so I really am almost a native, not quite, but I grew up here. And then I moved to L.A. in the early '60s and lived up there for almost twenty years, and then moved back to San Diego.

MR: So you've never done the New York thing?

MW: No. I spent a lot of time in New York. I've never actually resided there. I've been there for weeks at a time on different recording projects or playing. I've always regretted that and I always advise young players if they're really serious about doing something, sooner or later they have to deal with New York. They have to take that step and do it. And that discourages a lot of them right there. But I firmly believe that New York is the proving ground where ultimately you have to be able to hold your own, if you're looking for the kind of recognition and opportunities that are going to help build a career. Now you can play the music for the sheer satisfaction of playing the music, and even maybe make some kind of a living at it if you can also do other things as well, you know, play shows and do accompanying, which I've done quite a bit of over the years. You can do all of

those things anywhere, virtually, if it's an area of any size. But if you're serious about carving a place for yourself in the scheme of things, it has to be done in New York City. And it doesn't happen in Los Angeles, and it doesn't happen — now people can, once they've arrived in New York, can go anywhere and carry that attaché with them. I mean I know great New York players who now live in Santa Fe, New Mexico or wherever, but they will always be thought of as New York players. It doesn't matter. But if you haven't made that step there then it's very difficult. There are so many wonderful players on the west coast who just languished out here because there isn't the press out here, there isn't the springboard to Europe — just geographically you're at a disadvantage being on the west coast. There's Asia obviously but still it's really the proximity to Europe and the ability to travel over there, more so now than ever, I mean it's really true today, that I think many musicians depend on Europe for a big part of their employment each year, and for outlets for playing. But a lot of great players came from the west, went to New York, changed the music in New York, and are always thought of as New Yorkers, like Dexter Gordon and Charlie Mingus and Ornette Coleman, and on and on. But those were all Los Angeles players. But had they stayed in Los Angeles—

MR: We wouldn't know their names.

MW: You wouldn't know their names, that's right.

MR: What drew you to jazz as a young man?

MW: Well my mother was a part time night club singer. She usually worked days and sang somewhere in San Diego at least a few nights a week. She always loved singing and she was a good singer. And because of that, and also there were some other, I didn't come from a musician family in the professional sense, but an uncle was a violinist, and we were certainly a music oriented family, and there were some wonderful 78s that I always remember from my earliest childhood memories, that we had in the home, of course before LPs even. Bix Beiderbecke we had, and Billie Holiday specifically. I think maybe also some Eddie Condon and some other great stuff. But I specifically remember the Bix Beiderbecke and Billie Holiday 78s. And my earliest memories of jazz are those records, which is not a bad introduction, and you have to remember too how much more jazz there was, live jazz there was, on the radio in those days. There again that's virtually nonexistent today. We have one local jazz station at the community college here in San Diego that does have live broadcasts, I think once a month, but in most parts of the country that's a thing of the past. But there was a lot of live music on the radio in those days. Big bands and smaller groups from the Royal Roost in New York and all kinds of stuff that was on there, they called them remotes, and so you could hear Charlie Parker on the radio. And I don't remember hearing Bird, I was still too young to have heard those broadcasts or to have been aware of what was going on, but I remember vividly hearing

Art Tatum on the radio, and Teddy Wilson, and those, along with some of the early records that I mentioned that we had in the home I think were what — I was still too young to be thinking in terms of doing it, but at least it made that connection. The sound of that music seemed very special. It seemed very important compared to the pop music of the day. But actually I became more interested in classical music as I got older, and I was really primarily interested in trying writing—

MR: Composing class?

MW: Composing after some of the people that I really admired at that time, they were still relatively modern composers.

MR: Like?

MW: Bartok and Stravinsky and Hindemith.

MR: Wow.

MW: Well you know they're pretty traditional today in a lot of people's—

MR: Not to my ears.

MW: But that was pretty radical stuff, even in the '40s and early '50s. But I heard through a classmate, actually I played trombone in the school band at the high school, here at Point Loma High School, and the trombonist I sat next to, another kid my age, we were probably in about the tenth grade, had bought an LP. By this time there were ten inch LPs. And he said you've got to come over and hear this record I bought. And so I went by his house after school and it was Gerry Mulligan's tentet album, which is I think a classic recording, it was on I think Capitol Records and this would have been around 1953 or 4, probably '54, and it had Chet Baker and Art Pepper and a great L.A. band, and of course all of Gerry Mulligan's writing. And as I discovered a few years later when I became a little more knowledgeable, it was really all pretty much out of the Gil Evans/Miles Davis collaboration records. They were originally 45s I think. But I wasn't aware of them yet, and to me this was just breathtaking music, which it still holds up really well, if you're familiar with that album. So anyway the writing and the instrumentation, Gerry was using French horn and tuba and the colors and the swing, the time feel, the freedom in the soloing, the whole thing, I always remember that day as the day that I went from being maybe mildly interested in the music to being absolutely absorbed with it.

MR: I love to hear those little moments in a person's life that really make a difference. And if you hadn't sat down next to that fellow that day or whatever, or if he hadn't brought that record, things might have been different.

MW: Well he was much hipper than I was because he had the record, I didn't.

MR: Did you go get your own copy?

MW: Oh well then shortly, immediately I started grabbing everything I could. You know it's hard to imagine a time when, if there were maybe three or four new LPs a month in the stores, that was a pretty hot month. But now you have that many in an hour coming out.

MR: Isn't that curious. Because the market for jazz today, as we've talked about that the club scene is very poor and the jazz is not the overall popular music. Yet there's so much product.

MW: I know I was talking with someone about that just the other day. There's more than ever and yet the health of the music generally is not great, I mean as far as the real world of working and playing and performing and so on. I don't know. I don't have an answer to that. Someone said they thought it was economically a lot cheaper to produce than ever before perhaps, with modern technology, and that might have some bearing on it. I know companies used to be a lot more careful about I mean they would really screen people before they'd even consider recording them. It had to be someone who'd really paid some dues, and then they might get a chance, a shot at a record contract, at least one record. And I don't think that's as much the case today. I think there's a lot more kind of readiness to record people, and take a loss if necessary, because I don't think it's maybe as expensive as it was to produce CD's. Now I don't know, you'd have to talk to someone in the business to get the numbers, but that was one theory I heard.

MR: Well you can pretty much go out and make your own these days for not that much money too.

MW: Yeah, exactly. A lot of people do. They buy their own stampers and literally you can produce CDs at home now, and buy the jewel boxes. So I don't know. But then shortly after that then I discovered Monk and Miles and the people, the really historic people on the east coast who had changed the face of the music. And I had seen Duke live here when I was still a kid. His band came to town, and I remember seeing Jazz at the Phil, that came through. So you know I'd had some good roots in that area. And there was actually a really thriving music scene in San Diego when I was growing up. I was fortunate, because it was a Navy town and this was the war. San Diego was a jumping town between the service people that were stationed here and all of the people who came out here from all over the country to work in the plants, the aircraft plants and defense, night clubs were booming then and I mean like seven nights a week and Sunday matinees and there were great players here. Harold Land was here at one time, and there's a wonderful alto player in New York I've never met but he's from San Diego named Arthur Blythe. He's a marvelous player, I really admire him a lot, and I think he used to work around here in R&B bands, growing up in San Diego. And Walter Fuller was here, a trumpet player who'd been with Lionel Hampton's band and there were a lot of wonderful players. And so it was a good environment to grow up in.

MR: So from hearing these records and then deciding that this is something that I want to try to do, how did you teach yourself how to play jazz?

MW: Well I pretty much did myself. I had a series of, I started early studying which was fortunate, at about seven, but generally it was neighborhood piano teachers which in those days there was a piano teacher in almost every block, you know it was very common, part time piano teachers. There were pianos in most homes, or many homes anyway, and it was much more common to find pianos in someone's living room. And so I studied with a series of okay beginning teachers. But I've always regretted I never had one that was really a real task master, a real disciplinarian, because later on I had to go back and kind of re-teach myself a lot of things, correct a lot of bad habits that I had gotten away with early. But at least I did have the advantage of having started early. But really as far as whatever technical facility I have is pretty much self taught. I made myself later try to learn how to do it right or as best I could. But I did have one teacher, a man who was not particularly interested in teaching scales and Chopin etudes tunes or anything of that nature, but he was a Teddy Wilson fan and he played in that style, and played very well in that style. He had a great left hand stride style and the wonderful time feel and all. And I finally got with him when I was about twelve or thirteen. His name was Bill Franks and he's since deceased but he taught here for many years. And he was marvelous. Each week we would take songs and just reharmonize them. And he was marvelous at allowing a student the freedom to try things. And he would be encouraging, he would never say no you can't do that because it's not right. There was no right or wrong. He would just say well that's interesting. And then maybe if you tried this it might even be better. So that was a very positive input. But I used to take some really crazy ideas each week, a re-thinking of "Stardust" or something that I'm sure he was probably cringing some of that time at my attempts, but it was a wonderful opportunity for a young player to learn through someone like that. So anyway basically I am a self-taught player with a lot of help from this one particular teacher.

MR: Hindemith plays "Stardust," right?

MW: Well this was really before — I was interested in classical music but it was slightly later that I became interested in that aspect of music. But today it's such a different situation with so much jazz education and the young players today, so many of the pianists I hear, I mean they sound like conservatory-trained players, I mean as far as pure facility is concerned. Wonderful chops and they've obviously had — at least they sound to me as though they've had very, very good strong training. And that's another thing I try to encourage young players, I don't really teach, but if I do talk with a young player I always try to stress well whatever style you want to play, whatever you want to do as far

as jazz is concerned, get with a good classical teacher and learn how to really play the instrument. And they don't always want to hear that but — and then, go to New York.

MR: They could say, yeah, well watch Thelonious Monk playing.

MW: Well I know, sure. And it's hard to answer that.

MR: But you say he's Monk and you're not.

MW: Exactly.

MR: Right. What was the first important gig that, if you look back on it now, was there a series of gigs?

MW: Probably — I worked at The Lighthouse, which was a really famous club and really an institution, in Hermosa Beach which is just south of Los Angeles on the coast there. It was called The Lighthouse All-Stars was the band. Howard Rumsey, who lives near here by the way now, in Hemet, which is a city about an hour and a half from San Diego, he had a wonderful band there, a house band there, I'm sure you're familiar with The Lighthouse, and I was fortunate enough to play in that band for a few months in the — it would have been 1962 I guess. And before that I had just played around San Diego in clubs, with a lot of great players, a wonderful drummer named John Guerin, I don't know if you're familiar with his name, he's been in L.A. for years, he was from down here, we grew up together. And a trumpet player who died very young unfortunately, named Don Sleet, who did some recording, a wonderful player. There were some marvelous young players down here. But the first job where I actually got out of San Diego and did something on the L.A. scene anyway was with that band at The Lighthouse. And then shortly thereafter I worked with Shorty Rogers and his Giants which was a very well known band in those days. And by that time I was pretty much settled in L.A. and playing up there mostly.

MR: Did the players, like Shorty Rogers and yourself, did you consider that you were playing the west coast sound, or was that something that the east coast people put on your music?

MW: I never thought about it because really most of my heroes were players on the east coast, but having said that I mean there were such great players out here I almost hesitate to say — when I say "most" I mean maybe more back there than in L.A. But Hampton Hawes was active and really playing at his peak, and Carl Perkins, another great pianist who also died very young, Russ Freeman, I mean there were wonderful, wonderful players out here. And again as I alluded to earlier, had they gone back east and stayed back there they would have reached a much higher level of recognition than they ever did. But for whatever reasons they chose to stay out here. But they were the first people I heard live just because of the proximity. I mean I didn't go to the east coast until the early 1970s. So there was a long period where the only people I worked with or saw live really were primarily people out here. I saw traveling bands of course that would come out from New

York. I remember seeing Miles out in L.A. the first time. But you know that whole east coast/west coast thing, by the '60s I think it had somewhat subsided. That was more of a journalistic big deal in the '50s. And I think it sold a lot of records in both directions and it created kind of a stir, you know there's nothing like some kind of a real or fictional rivalry to kind of whip things up and get a little more press maybe. But it was very real. I remember the articles that would come out about east coast and west coast, and some albums would make some reference in their titles "East Meets West," and so it was definitely happening. But I think by the '60s that had kind of worn itself out. There is no question that there are people — there's a New York attitude that — just as in the famous map, is it Steinberg? The artist? The *New Yorker* artist that, in a nutshell, there's nothing west of the Hudson.

MR: Oh he did the thing with all New York and in back there's this teeny little—

MW: That's a very astute summing up of the New York attitude, I think about most everything in general, not just jazz music. And when you leave New York you're not going anywhere is kind of the attitude. So I think to that extent I mean certainly never out here, there was never any discrimination against the east, I mean everybody out here genuinely admired everybody back there. And as I said earlier, a lot of people back there had been out here originally anyway. But there's a lot of it. I mean to this day in New York you get a certain amount of that. That just kind of goes with the territory. And it never bothered me. I mean I admired what was going on there so much and the players so much, I felt they were entitled to that, they had earned it. If you've paid your dues there over a period of time, you can have whatever attitude you want as far as that's concerned. Because it's tough there. It's tough to survive, the weather's tough, so yeah, I admire those guys.

MR: You've accompanied some great singers.

MW: Yes, I've been very fortunate.

MR: Sarah Vaughan for one. How did that come about?

MW: I'm never really sure. I was with her two years, two separate years. I worked with her 12 months in '79 and then left and went back in '83 and worked another full year. But I think I probably initially got the job through Roy McCurdy who was a good friend of mine and we had played together a lot when he came off the road after he'd been with Cannon for so long, he settled in L.A. And Sarah had called him I think as I remember, she was putting together a new back-up trio and she had called Roy first and I think Roy then had recommended me and Andy Simpkins was the bass player. And so that was the trio for the first year for the most part. Roy'd left at one point and Grady Tate was with us for a while, and then Harold Jones finished that first year. So I played with several different drummers. Andy Simpkins stayed with her actually up until her death. Then I left to do some other things and went back in '83 when there was another opening with

her, and at that point it was still Andy and Harold Jones still. So we had a good time. And Sarah was just fantastic.

MR: Yeah?

MW: Yeah.

MR: Easy to work with?

MW: The easiest singer I've ever worked with, of any I can think of. I mean just absolutely professional. I never heard Sarah complain once about anything, unless it was a legitimate mess-up, if a sound man or a lighting man or someone wasn't taking care of business and doing their job, she'd be all over them, and rightfully so. But I never ever heard her complain about not feeling good, having a cold, having a sore throat, having sinus problems, and there were a lot of times when I know she didn't feel good, traveling as hard as we did, because we traveled almost constantly. And it's pretty remarkable because there are very few singers you could say that about. She was really unique.

MR: Did she allow you — I don't know if "allow" is the right word but — I assume that you did some experimenting with different chord changes and stuff from night to night, and did you ever play anything that would make her kind of look at you like — I'm not sure that works?

MW: Not with Sarah. I have to qualify that a little bit. There was more freedom with her than with anyone I've ever worked with, including the biggest names down to the most kind of beginning singers that I worked with early on when I was first starting to accompany. She didn't need any help at all. She knew exactly what she was doing. The only place you could get in trouble is she would give you so much freedom that if you got carried away and got yourself out on a limb somewhere harmonically or whatever, she would go with you. I mean she heard everything. And she would go with you into these territories, well if you weren't prepared to follow through and didn't have a pretty good idea of where you wanted this to end up, you could feel pretty foolish, and then at that point she might give you the ray you know. But I don't remember that happening more than maybe a couple of times in the two years I was with her, because you couldn't throw her. I mean it's not like with so many pretty good singers where if you go too far they're lost. They're not going to be able to get it back together. That never happened with Sarah. She just was too astute. And she was an excellent pianist herself, a very good musician. She knew chords, she could sight read, she was a musician. So anyway, no, she was the easiest to accompany of anyone, because there were no predetermined parameters or rules. The one thing she did do is repeat her sets a lot. We didn't change material very often. We would sometimes for months at a time we would perform pretty much the same show with maybe a few — you know she would give me the free reign to maybe juggle some things here and there, but for the most part we didn't introduce a lot of new material all the time.

So you have to, to keep it interesting for everybody, you have to try to find interesting little switches on things and a new take on something. So that's a challenge. When you're doing new material all the time you don't maybe even have the time to think about that kind of stuff. So it was great. Ella, who I worked with later, what can you say about Ella? I mean we all know how remarkable Ella Fitzgerald was. Ella was a different kind of singer. Ella was more specific in what she needed to hear behind her and wanted to hear. And it was great too, it was just a different kind of thing. It was more tailoring what you do to make what she needed happen and work. Sarah was more of a bebopper in that sense. And of course when you understand the history of her early years it's understandable, I mean coming up with the people she did.

MR: Right. Was Ella's — I had read that she tended to be, even as great as she was, quite nervous about coming on stage.

MW: Yes, she was. She was. If Sarah was, she hid it very well. I was never ever aware of any nervousness. You never know for sure what's going on inside someone, but Ella was like I think many accomplished actors and actresses and singers, and even people who've done it for decades talk about how nervous they are before they go out. Lawrence Olivier or someone talking about that they still get butterflies you know. I believe when he was still alive I think I remember hearing that comment in one interview from him. You can't imagine that this person would still get butterflies. But Ella did. But then the minute she hit the stage, which is often the case with performers, that was gone and she was fine. I never sensed a moment's lack of self assurance or any stage nerves once she hit the stage. But she'd be pacing around back stage before they announced her. And that's really more typical I think than Sarah. Sarah was very unusual in not having that.

MR: I see you were part of the "All That Jazz" the Grammy award winner. Did you get a Grammy for that?

MW: No it didn't. Actually that was the first time I had worked with Ella. I got called to do that session. Actually there were a total of four sessions, I did two of them, Kenny Barron did — I think I did three and Kenny did one or something like that for that CD. And then on the basis — I think as I realized later, I think Norman Granz knew he was going to have to find someone for Ella because Paul Smith was leaving, the accompanist who had been with her. And I think he hired me to do the CD to see how we worked together. Because I did, prior to actually going into the studio I did go to the house a couple of times and Ella and I would work out some things and keys and tempos and so on, and I think that was kind of Norman's way of seeing what the chemistry was like and if I would be right. And apparently on the basis of how things went he and she felt comfortable. And not too long after we did the recordings for the CD, their office called me to see if I wanted to start doing the touring, which by that time was not that heavy. You know Ella was going out

oh maybe just a few days a month. We might be gone a total of a week out of a month maybe. In her prime, earlier, before she'd had some health problems, I think she was on the road about 50 weeks out of the year, like Sarah. But she had to curtail some of that. Her doctors had forced her to. But we still were out there quite a bit.

MR: Has there been a time in your career where you've been tempted — either because financially or just because you were looking for something different where you got into non-musical jobs?

MW: Only in the beginning. About 1957 it would have been when I was first married, I worked for about six months at an aircraft plant at Hughes Aircraft in Los Angeles, as a draftsman and industrial artist, which that isn't even done anymore, it's all graphic art now. We used to actually use pencils and sit at drafting boards if you could believe that.

MR: Right.

MW: And T-squares. But that was for about six months and other than that I have — well I have been just in the music business. Not always just jazz, I've done a lot of different kinds of work. You really have to to survive if you're not going to teach or have some other means of support. So I've done a lot of show work and strip joints and everything.

MR: I was going to say, what was the job where you said man I can't believe I'm doing this. Has there been one?

MW: Well I've never, from as early on as I can remember, before I was even in the union, just a kid playing in high school gyms and stuff, I never turned down work. I think I must have figured out very early on that you better not turn down work, because there may not be any next week. And still to this day I find it very difficult to turn something down, unless it's just absolutely not right. I mean I've always been kind of a blue collar musician. I mean I work and I think really it's a detriment in some ways, because you dissipate your energies and your creativity to a certain extent by taking that approach to the business. I think a truer artistic approach, where you only do, as guys I've known, who only do what they want to do, only do what they feel is pure and untainted and artistically correct, if you can survive doing that I think it is better in a lot of ways. Because I think you save your energies for that focus. If you're doing too many different kinds of things in this business I think it's very hard to stay focused. And so there is a down side to that work ethic.

MR: Well I know what you're talking about.

MW: You know what I mean exactly.

MR: And you can get a lot of calls to do lots of different kinds of things, and perhaps the thing that you are looking to really excel at does suffer a bit, but as you said there's a practical side to life that requires you to take those things, because they're paying.

MW: Well if you're raising a family and here again if you're single and are in a different situation you have a lot more freedom to say no. But for various reasons I just have always felt, hey if the phone rings, it might be foolish to turn it down. So I've done a lot of things. So anyway in answer to your question, I'd never felt like I was above doing a certain kind of job. The only thing that's ever bummed me, like with all of us I guess, is when it turns out that it's really bad, just the playing is bad, if it's a horrible singer you end up with for four hours accompanying or just a band that's hopeless or whatever, then you're just waiting for it to be over and you're thinking maybe why did I get into this. But we all go through those experiences. And a lot of times coming up I was lucky to be even in that good a band because I was still learning myself and as Art Tatum, I remember he said in an interview I heard a few years ago on the radio, that he had never heard a pianist he couldn't learn from, which is kind of the same thing. I mean you're going to learn from even the worst situations.

MR: Yeah. You can learn what not to do also.

MW: What not to do or avoid, or how not to play.

MR: Or how not to act.

MW: But I think Tatum really meant that when he said it. But I've done a lot of different kinds of work and then I ended up doing studio work in L.A. in Hollywood from about late '60s to the late '70s, about a ten year period. And I didn't set out to do that. I don't think many guys in the studios, men or women, set out to become studio players. I mean that's not like a lifelong dream as a kid, it just happens. If you're in a particular area like Los Angeles or New York where there's a lot of that work and you happen to get a few of the calls, and if you're halfway good at it, word of mouth and referrals, you begin to get a few more calls. So I ended up doing a lot of that. And it was a great experience really, because among other things I had to really go back and woodshed the instrument. Some of the stuff you're called upon to do in a motion picture score for instance, really requires some pretty serious playing as far as sight reading and performance skills. And it forced me to kind of, again to re-evaluate my own playing. A lot of it was just craft, it wasn't high art you know, playing on a T.V. show score. But within that context you can still get a lot out of it.

MR: Do you ever hear anything on the television reruns or whatever, and say hey, I played on that?

MW: You know I hardly watch television, I'm sure there are, I still get checks for stuff, a show that's playing in Finland that I did in 1967 or something. But I don't watch enough T.V. to know. But I know, yeah, that some of them are still playing. I did a Rice-a-Roni commercial that was on for about twenty years.

MR: [sings] Rice-a-Roni.

MW: That's the one.

MR: What was your part in that?

MW: It was actually a very good writer, a guy named Don Specht who was a jazz, a Bud Powell piano player. He could sit down and sound just like Bud Powell. But he, like a lot of guys, he'd gotten into writing jingles and he was good at it, and he always hired the hippest players — he'd have Shelly Manne and Joe Pass or whoever, and doing these kind of idiotic little jingles, but he'd try to make them as good as he could and have good players. So I hadn't thought of that in years. Something triggered that. But I probably shouldn't even mention that.

MR: No. Those things are great. And that's what — people I don't think have a realistic picture of what jazz musicians, or a lot of musicians, how they really make a living. That playing with Ella and the list of people you've played with, Zoot Sims and Sweets Edison, those are great moments, and you're recording here, but that doesn't happen every single day.

MW: No. Those are the highlights and high points. But unless you maybe were touring for long periods with a Stan Getz, or — like for instance I worked with Stan in different venues, concert situations, but never to tour, for like six months or whatever. So yeah, you have to fill up the rest of your time with other stuff, and so I've done a lot of stuff. I said to somebody recently, I've done just about everything except maybe play in a circus band, because they didn't use keyboards then, now they do. But a lot of it has just been kind of I guess daring or something. I never thought of it that way, but I used to, again kind of in keeping with what we were talking about, I would, like with a lot of studio work, I would just say yes, and hope that I could pull it off, and a lot of it was just on the job training. If I'd had more sense I guess I would have said I'd better pass on this, I don't think I can do it. And you just get in there and you figure out how to do it because you're expected to, and you're going to look pretty stupid if you can't.

MR: Well you said a couple of minutes ago you were talking about the studio music and you said most of it was just craft. And at first I thought you were going to say crap. But I think it's a telling thing that you didn't say that, because even playing on a Rice-a-Roni commercial, you have to do what's required, and not more. Because I've heard plenty of players who can play the piano like crazy but they don't understand the gig — if it's solo piano if it's in a restaurant or something.

MW: Yeah. And that's where the professional, again, yeah you're absolutely right. There's craft and there's art as far as I'm concerned. It's kind of like the old line, years ago someone said, "There's music and there's the music business." And they're very often two very different things. Yeah. On any given day in a Hollywood studio, and it would be the same in New York, I was sitting with the greatest players in the world, guys who

517 could sit in a symphony orchestra, who could do all kinds of stuff. So there was nothing
518 demeaning or ridiculous about being there, I mean you were lucky to be there. But a lot
519 of times the product you were going for was maybe — this, we're not talking here Pierre
520 Boulez, but on the other hand, in many cases it was wonderful music, great writers who
521 took it very seriously, even if it was just fairly innocuous film, took the writing very
522 seriously. I worked for Dave Grusin a lot. Dave Grusin wrote beautiful stuff for some
523 comedy shows we used to do and the string writing and everything would be absolutely
524 gorgeous. Tom Scott and some of those people.
525 MR: You want me to pause for a second? Yes, tell him I'll call him a little bit later. Ray
526 Conniff is coming tomorrow.
527 MW: Oh. You let me know your time frame too, it's two o'clock.
528 So anyway, yeah, you know studio work was just something that happened. And about
529 that same time jazz went into another one of its declines, you know the late '60s, early
530 '70s was a very difficult time for jazz. I mean there have been all these valleys over there,
531 and that was one of them. And at the time it just seemed like again it was partly survival.
532 There's no point in starving. I mean you just do what you have to do. And if there'd been
533 more interesting stuff going on to do I would have tried to do that. But at that particular
534 point in my life it was good work, and I did learn a lot about it as a player and even as a
535 writer. And I sat with some really wonderful players.
536 MR: Do you have a family? Children?
537 MW: Yeah. I have, my wife and I combined it's not our first marriage for either — and we
538 have six children between us and grandchildren. So we have a pretty widespread family
539 now.
540 MR: Are there musicians in the family?
541 MW: No. Actually I have a grandson right now who seems to have probably some interest but
542 it's too soon to tell. But I never encouraged it. I knew how hard it was, and I never
543 pushed music and I really think that if — I'm sure the same would be true of acting or
544 any of the arts, if a child is determined to do it, they'll do it no matter what you tell them.
545 And if they don't have that determination they probably shouldn't do it. So there's really,
546 you know the whole subject of encouragement I think is a difficult one.
547 MR: Right. Do you think they had a sense, your children, of what you did for a living? Did
548 they understand it? Did they think it was a little out of the ordinary?
549 MW: You know that's an interesting question, Monk, I've never really thought of it that way.
550 A couple of my older kids when they were still little actually I would take on, for
551 instance, studio calls with me, just to see if they would find that interesting, and like what
552 did you do at the office today. And they always seemed to enjoy it, that sort of thing. But
553 generally I'd say no. I think Dad just went off to do what he does. I'm not sure—

MR: Right. Kids take it in stride. Do you have a gig tonight? — I remember my own little kids saying that at a very early age. "Dad, you got a gig tonight?" You were just going to work.

MW: Sure, yeah.

MR: That's great. What's in the close future for you? More of the same?

MW: Well I still travel some. I stay primarily in San Diego. I do some work in L.A. I just was up there earlier this week, I worked with Ray Brown on some recordings up there, with a wonderful — the first time I'd worked with him, I'd admired him on recordings but first time I'd met him or worked with him, Ralph Moore, a wonderful tenor and soprano player. Marvelous. He is now in L.A. I didn't realize that. I thought he was still in New York but you know so many guys have moved out here, and I had a drummer named Greg Hutchinson, whose a marvelous young drummer. Ralph's out here to do The Tonight Show. He's part of The Tonight Show band, Jay Leno's show. So that's what he's doing out here. So anyway I do get up there to do some things, but I've become more interested in kind of experimental music and it's still jazz oriented but I've moved away from mainstream jazz as such, as far as my own projects. I still do a certain amount of that when I'm called to do so you know. But I have a group here in San Diego called Live Music which is an interesting combination of instrumentation.

MR: Any electronic sounds involved?

MW: It's primarily still acoustic, but the violinist, who is also a guitarist, Art Johnson, who was in Los Angeles for years, uses electric violin at times. But it's primarily an acoustic group, acoustic bass and drums, but cello and bass clarinet and various interesting combinations of instruments, and we're doing a lot more exploratory kind of improvisational music. It's really probably closer to the classical world than jazz as such, although everyone is from the jazz world, all the players are. So I'm more and more, as far as my own personal projects, I'm more interested in where do we go from here.

MR: Do you recall a record by Roger Kellaway, the "Cello Quartet?"

MW: Oh, certainly yeah.

MR: That was some nice stuff there.

MW: Roger had not been in L.A. very long. He had come out from New York when he did that and he had only been in L.A. a year or two when I first met him out here. I'd been aware of him from an early recording he'd made in New York, but yeah, that's an interesting, and John Guerin is the drummer, the drummer I mentioned earlier, and Chuck Domenico. But again, for someone, I'm sixty years old, and particularly for people my age, both the players and the audience, usually I find in talking with them they have become pretty much stuck somewhere as far as what they consider good and bad and what they want to hear, what they don't want to hear, what's B.S. and what isn't. And I don't want that to

happen. I feel very strongly that that's not — I don't want that to be the way one ages. I think it's much more important — I'm really fascinated with what young people are thinking and how they hear it and how they see it. And I think world music, for lack of a better category, is here definitely bigger than ever. I think Cuban music obviously is having a tremendous effect on what goes on here. I think in the next few years we're going to see more and more of that influence. And so much of what goes on in the rock world, and in the classical world is so interesting that it's a shame to miss it, I think. I mean I love everything that I grew up with, and have so much admiration for all of that, but I have the hardest time with people who say well I love Charlie Parker but I don't understand what these kids are trying to do. And it's exactly what people said about Charlie Parker in his day. It's like they can't see the irony that they are simply stuck the same way. And if Bird were alive I would hope that he would be trying to understand what some kid was doing. So anyway, that's just a personal reflection in looking back.

MR: Well it's a good insight. And I think a good—

MW: It's hard to stay that way. As you get older inevitably you start to shut down. It's just part of what happens I think. I think you need to fight it as long as you can.

MR: I'll have to remember that when I get home and my 15 year old turns on her music.

MW: Yeah. I know. Well you know, not all of it's good but there's some interesting stuff going on and if you want to call it post modern, turn of the century attitude or whatever.

MR: It's pretty funny too because something she's listening to now, the guy's playing an old Wurlitzer electronic piano.

MW: I know. Amazing, huh? And Farfisas.

MR: Yeah. Hey, the classics will always be.

MW: Who'd have thought?

MR: Yeah. Well this is great. I'm pleased you were able to come and join us today.

MW: Oh, my pleasure, I really enjoyed it. Yeah, great to be here.

MR: On behalf of the college I'd like to thank you, and I hope your experimental group flourishes.

MW: I hope. You know, talk about few venues, that's the hardest part of that kind of project is just finding outlets.

MR: A little art center somewhere that you hope for.

MW: I have to scrounge around. But they're there.

MR: Right, Okay.

MW: Thanks so much.

MR: Good luck to you.